Measurement of Inequality and Discrimination

Week 5: Equality of opportunity

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Concepts around equality of opportunity

1. Meritocracy
   "The job should go to the applicant who is best qualified."
   "Economic benefits should be rewarded proportional to societal contribution."
2. Desertism
   "Poor people don't deserve their fate."
   "People who work hard deserve greater rewards."
3. Equality of Opportunity
   "It should be possible to achieve success regardless of background."
   "Institutions should not discriminate on the basis of race and gender."

Equality of Opportunity

- Formal equality of opportunity
  - Civil Rights Act of 1964
  - Article 14 of the ECHR, Article 21 CFREU
- Substantive equality of opportunity
- Radical equality of opportunity / Luck egalitarianism



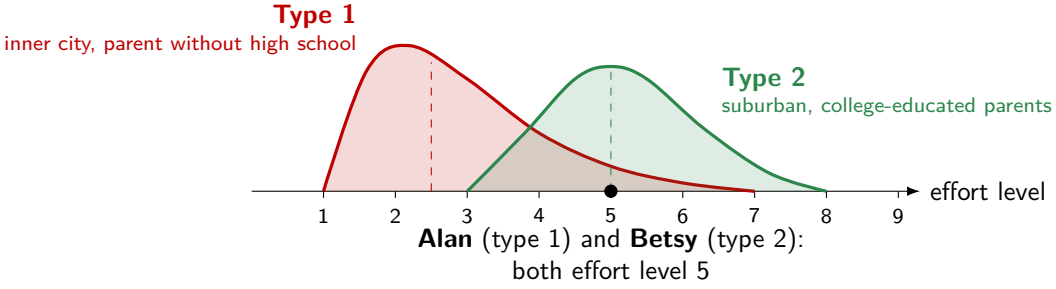
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Luck egalitarianism

1. *"Circumstances" should not causally affect the attainment of economic benefits.*
2. *"Matters of responsibility" should affect the attainment of economic benefits.*

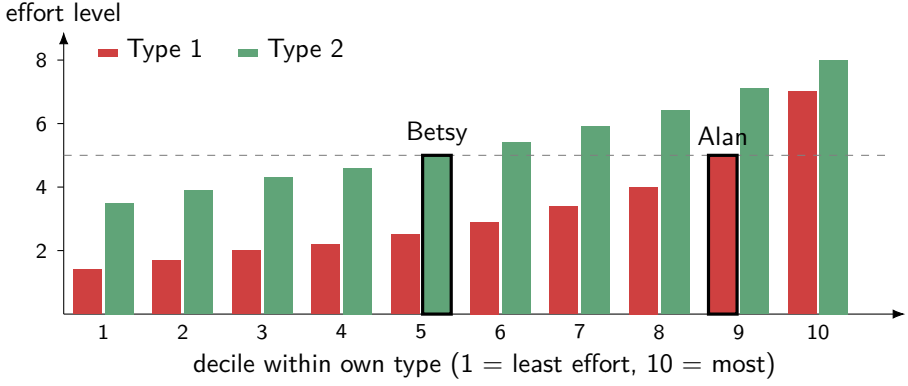
- **Circumstances**: social class, geographical area, ethnicity, etc.
  or: anything outside one's control
- **Matters of responsibility**: effort, choices

Types



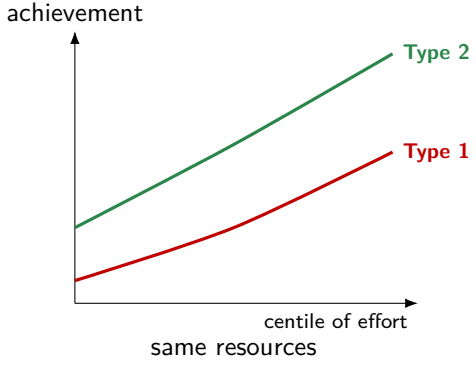
Roemer (1998, pp. 8–9, 13–14)

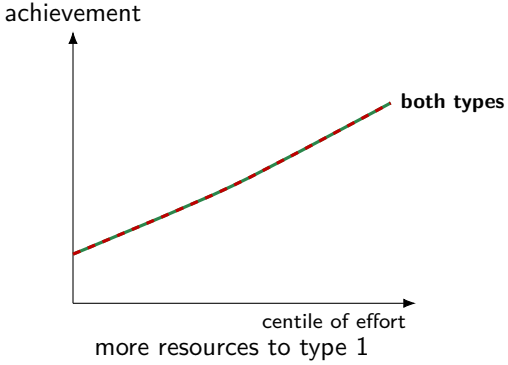
Degree of effort: your decile within your type



Same **level** of effort (5), different **degree**: Alan is in decile 9, Betsy in decile 5.
"Alan has tried harder than Betsy" (p. 14)

The equal-opportunity policy

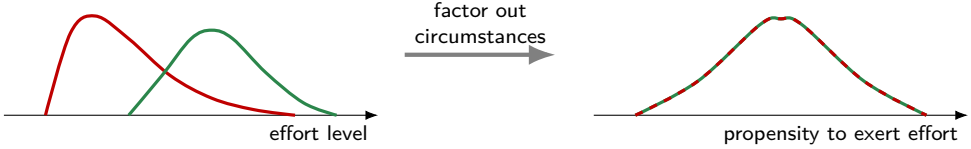




"those who apply equal degrees of effort end up with equal achievement, regardless of their circumstances"

(Roemer, 1998, p. 12)

The assumption of charity



with circumstances

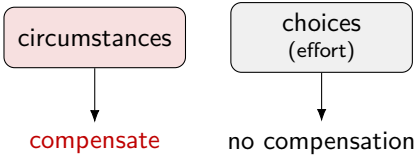
the same in every type

"within any type, that distribution [of propensity to exert effort] would be the same, were we able to factor out the (different) circumstances which define different types"

(Roemer, 1998, p. 15)

Risse (2002): two ideas in Roemer

Dichotomy

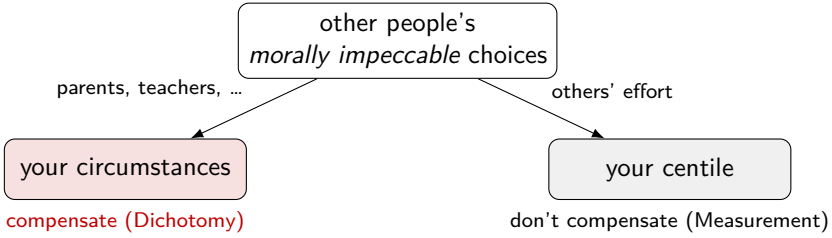


Measurement



pp. 732–733

Should other people's choices be compensated?



All-Choices

× all below the top centile compensated: equal outcomes

No-Choices

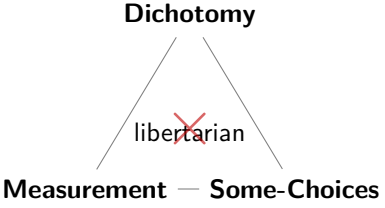
× a third category: beyond control, not compensated

Some-Choices

needs a principled line between the two arrows

pp. 734–737

The central argument (Risse, 2002, p. 738)



Circumstances are compensated because they are **beyond your control**.

↓

Others' choices that fix your centile are **also beyond your control**.

↓

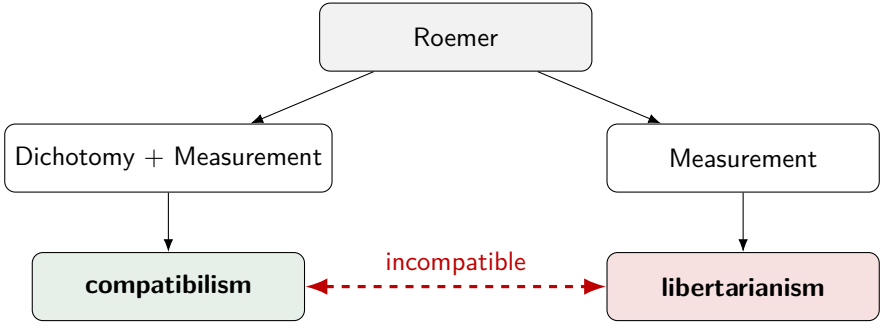
So they must be compensated too.

↓

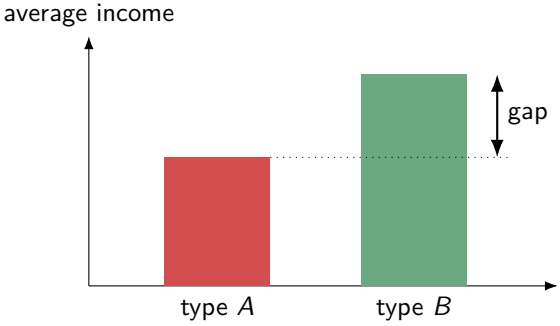
Some-Choices fails, given Measurement.

"compensation based on circumstances and compensation based on other people's choices stand and fall together" (p. 738)

Risse's conclusion: Roemer pulls in two directions

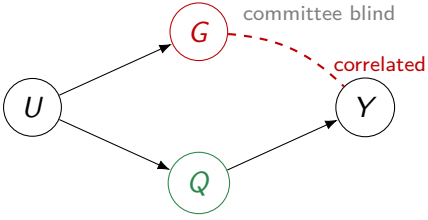


Reading: Ackermans (2022, Sections 1–4)



? Is this gap *inequality of opportunity*?

Correlation is not enough (Section 2.1)

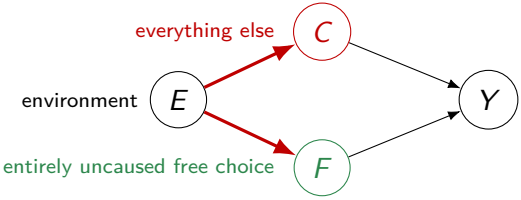


U: upbringing
G: group A/B (circumstance)
Q: application quality (effort)
Y: admitted

1. Group and admission are **correlated** (through upbringing).
2. But group does not **cause** admission: the committee is blind.
3. Intuitively, there is **no inequality of opportunity**.
4. A correlational measure (the gap in averages) says there is.

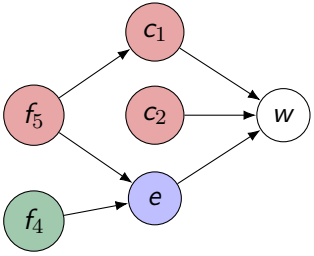
$\Rightarrow$ A measure of inequality of opportunity must track **causation**, not correlation.

Objection 1: free will (Section 4.1)

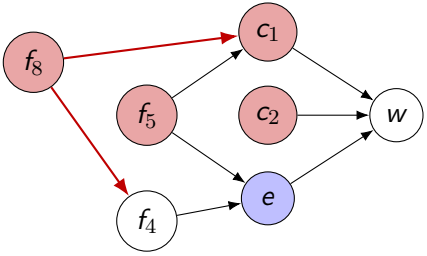


- Free choices can have *some* causes: the bribed poll worker is still responsible.
- Entirely uncaused choices are rare, or do not exist.
  $\Rightarrow$ equality of opportunity **collapses into equality of outcome**.

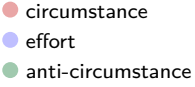
Objection 2: common causes are circumstances (Section 4.2)



(a) f_4 is an anti-circumstance



(b) one more common cause f_8:
no anti-circumstance left



Proposal: every common cause of a circumstance and effort is itself a circumstance.

The more causal history we add, the fewer anti-circumstances remain.
$\Rightarrow$ again **equality of outcome**.

References I


Ackermans, L. B. (2022). Causal bias in measures of inequality of opportunity. *Synthese*, *200*(6), 429.


Risse, M. (2002). What equality of opportunity could not be. *Ethics*, *112*(4), 720–747.


Roemer, J. E. (1998). *Equality of opportunity*. Harvard University Press.